St. Egbert Organ Replacement Project

A proposal

BLUF / TL;DR

The organ at St. Egbert's is now more than 30 years old, making it vulnerable to part failures and ongoing repairs. Its sound sampling technology is outdated and uninspiring by modern standards, and the instrument itself is undersized for the church and the parish's music ministry program. The parish should begin proactively planning and raising money to replace it within the next few years, aiming to do so before it stops working to a degree that it is unfeasible to repair. Estimated project cost for 2026 is **$212,000** (all inclusive), with prices increasing roughly 10-15% each year—another reason to act sooner rather than later.

The recommended target organ for St. Egbert Church is an **Allen III/58** three-manual instrument at an estimated price of **$211,578** (cost breakdown below).

This proposal details why a new organ is needed, identifies and justifies the ideal replacement instrument, and provides an analysis of alternatives. Templated fundraising materials—an informational pamphlet and a fundraising pledge page—are appended for consideration as well.



Figure 1: The Allen III/58 three-manual organ features *"APEX II Technology [offering] the pinnacle of organ design for the 21st century. Combining the most advanced tone generation technology, unique features, build quality and product longevity."* (Allen Organ)

Terminology

The following terminology is used throughout the proposal and defined here for convenience.

- **Console:** The part of the organ containing the manuals, pedalboard, and stop controls.
- **Coupler:** Feature that allows stops from one division of the organ to be played on a different division for greater flexibility.
- **Division:** Groups of pipes in a pipe organ based on which keyboard they are played from. Some divisions are *enclosed*, meaning the pipes are located behind large sound-dampening shutters that allow the organist to dampen the sound, thereby decreasing the volume. Other divisions are *unenclosed*, meaning the pipes are fully exposed with no volume control.
  - **Great division:** The main division of the organ producing the strongest vibrant sound that most people associate with organs. Used primarily to support congregational singing.
  - **Swell division:** The second division on a two-manual organ named after the swell shades behind which its pipes are located to offer volume control. Useful for accompanying cantors or soloists.
  - **Choir division:** The third division on a three-manual organ, usually enclosed, but with a slightly stronger sound than the Swell division but not as strong as the Great. Useful for accompanying choirs or ensembles when foundational but not overpowering registrations are needed.
  - **Pedal division:** The pipes played exclusively by the pedalboard.
- **Manual:** A keyboard consisting of 64 keys played with the hands.
- **Pedalboard:** A keyboard played with the feet controlling the lowest pitches of the organ.
- **Piston:** A programmable button used to set registrations for quick access during playing.
- **Rank:** A group of pipes, one per note, that have the same sound quality and timber but differ only in pitch from note to note. Each rank has its own unique sound, purpose, and use.
- **Registration:** Combination of stops used to produce desired sound while playing.
- **Shoe:** A pedal used to control a part of the organ:
  - **Swell** or **expression shoe:** Opens and closes the swell shades (wooden "shutters") on a pipe organ to vary the volume of enclosed divisions.
  - **Crescendo shoe:** Systematically adds stops to gradually and organically build up the volume of the instrument while being played.
- **Stop:** A subset of a rank of pipes based on their speaking pitch ranging from 32' pedal stops providing bass foundation to 2' (or smaller) manual stops that give bright high pitched sounds. Stop families include *principals* (full, strong, vibrant sound), *flutes* (softer sound that resembles flutes and wind instruments), strings, and *reeds* (nasally, "edgy" sounds that resemble reed instruments). Each stop has its own unique sound, purpose, and use.
- **Voicing:** The tuning of the sound quality (*e.g.*, bass, timbre) of every note of every stop on the organ to ensure everything is balanced properly.

Overview

The current organ at St. Egbert's is a two-manual Allen MDS-6 AK digital computer organ installed in September 1994 featuring sound technology from the late 1980s. Digital organs are budget organs for churches that are unable to afford a full pipe organ, which can cost 5-10x as much as a comparable digital organ. Pipe organs, when properly maintained, can outlive the building in which they are installed. Digital organs, on the other hand, are more like electronic appliances with an unavoidable shelf life. While there are digital organs that are more than 50 years old still in use, they are not the norm and have most certainly undergone expensive repairs over their lifetime. On average, churches should expect to replace a digital organ every 30-40 years or else budget generously every year for ongoing repairs and be willing to spend what is needed to keep an old instrument in use.

The primary points of failure for digital organs are outdated electronics and technology. While Allen advertises indefinite support and repair of any organ they have ever sold, the reality is that, as instruments age, parts become increasingly difficult to obtain as old technology is replaced by newer state-of-the-art counterparts. Eventually, old parts are no longer made. At 32 years old, St. Egbert's is at risk of confronting this if the sound module (*i.e.*, the motherboard or "guts" of the organ) dies. If this were to happen, the sound board would need to be replaced with the same part off an equally old organ turned in for parts. For an estimated cost of around $15-20k (as of 2025), the church would end up replacing a 30+ year old sound module with another 30+ year old module, with no way of knowing how long this equally-old part itself would last.

The catalyst for this project has been a couple repairs needed in the last two years: a power supply in 2024 and an audio control switch in 2025. At risk of future failure are the amplifiers, speakers, sound module, and other controls, to name a few. As St. Egbert's enters this last quarter of the average digital organ's life, the parish would be prudent to begin proactively fundraising now so that it can comfortably replace it with something fitting for the church *before* the congregation finds itself desperately needing to quickly raise money for a dead instrument.[1]

Replacing a digital organ presents exciting opportunities for a parish, not the least of which is a significant upgrade in audio technology. Computers have come a long way since 1994, and so too have digital computer organs. It is also an opportunity for the parish to reflect on its current music ministry program, envision its future, and select a suitable instrument capable of serving the parish's needs and fulfilling its musical dreams. For St. Egbert's, this means choosing an instrument that is sufficiently flexible to lead the congregation, cantors, a choir, and instrumentalists, and is installed in such a way that the sound is balanced throughout the entire church.

Considerations for the existing organ

1. Part failures due to age

At 32 years old (as of 2026), the current organ has reached the age at which most digital organs need to be replaced unless the church wants to spend money on keeping old technology running. In Advent 2024, the power supply for the organ failed spectacularly in the middle of a Sunday liturgy. When this happened, every note of every stop on the organ started sounding continuously at full volume, a consequence of improperly regulated power being received by the sound board. All that

[1] Like what recently happened with the HVAC system in Moselein Hall, when the parish needed to raise $70k as quickly as possible to restore air conditioning and prevent mold growth in the middle of summer.

could be done was switch the organ off, rendering it unusable right before Christmas. The service call plus parts and labor cost a few thousand dollars. Fortunately, power supplies are not specialized parts, so a newer model was able to be installed.

Roughly a year later, an audio control switch failed, rendering half of the organ unusable. Because of the way old organs were designed, "half of the organ" meant that seemingly random stops across all divisions and within families of stops were affected. For example, in the Great division, the 8' principal stop became inoperable while the 4' principal stop still worked, and the 8' flute stop in the Great division worked but the 4' flute did not. The situation was similar in the Swell and Pedal divisions as well. This made it impossible to properly register the instrument for hymn singing and other musical needs. This service call plus parts and labor was another $2000 or so.

To be fair, Allen commits to repairing any organ it has ever sold—and repairs, even cumulatively, do cost a fraction of the price of a new instrument. The two recent repairs together cost just under $10k. But this is because neither involved specialized parts: while the original power supply is no longer made, it could be replaced with a newer model because power supplies are universal, and the switch, while not used on new organs anymore, was used by Allen for a sufficiently long period of time that new ones (*i.e.*, unused units still in stock) could still be acquired. Challenges arise, however, when parts that are no longer made and are no longer able to be acquired need replacing. The most critical example of this is the sound module, the motherboard or "guts" of the organ, the "digital computer" component that creates the sounds. This part, while state-of-the-art at the time, is no longer made, and because technology advances so rapidly, new models are not backwards compatible with old organs. And herein lies the critical caveat to Allen's commitment: there comes a time when the only way to make certain repairs to an old organ is to replace old technology with the same old technology—in other words, an equally-old used part pulled off a similarly aged organ scrapped for parts. Allen service technicians will do this, and the price will still be much less than a new organ. The Eastern North Carolina Allen service technician, for example, estimated the cost for replacing the current sound board, should it be needed, to be tens of thousands of dollars in 2026—but for another 30+ year old part that could itself fail at any time.

The parish should carefully consider this reality and think about it like maintaining an old car. With enough money and trips to a trusted mechanic, any car can remain on the road indefinitely. But it still remains an old car with old technology and missing features. Is it worthwhile? It should be noted that there are dozens of other switches in the current organ, and service calls to replace them one at a time as they fail will add up. The most expensive repair would be the sound module, as mentioned. Other parts at risk of failing include the speakers (*i.e.* dried out and blown speaker cones), amplifiers (one for each of the two channels), the digital transposer, mechanical stop rails, and the expression shoe, to name a few.

2. Outdated audio technology

As the name implies, digital computer organs use onboard computers to replicate organ stops. Computers – and all digital technology – have come a long way in 30+ years. Built and installed in 1994, the current organ uses technology from the late 1980s and early 1990s. Each stop is digitally synthesized, meaning the sound is digitally imitated to the best of the ability of the technology at the time. While state-of-the-art in 1994, by modern standards, the sound generated by this organ is underwhelming, unconvincing, and uninspiring. Nowadays, the best pipe organs around the world are carefully and professionally recorded using top-of-the-line recording equipment. These recordings

are essentially played back when keys are played on modern organs, making the sound of properly installed and properly voiced new digital instruments indistinguishable from real pipe organs.

Interestingly, the majority of churches that replace old digital organs with new modern instruments experience notable increases in congregational singing and participation in music. The reason can likely be attributed to the same reason the Catholic church holds the pipe organ in the highest esteem above all other instruments: its unique ability to imitate the human voice. Both organs and the human voice are wind instruments whereby sound is created by moving air through a pipe. It turns out that the human ear is keenly sensitive to the authenticity of such sound. The authenticity of modern audio sampling and reproduction enhances our experience of the music it produces and inspires us to sing. Unfortunately, most parishes do not know what they are missing until or unless they invest in the upgrade to modern, stunningly authentic sound quality.

3. Organ is too small for liturgical and music ministry needs

The current organ is one of the smallest church organs Allen made at the time. The fact that it has an internal speaker in the console suggests that this model was intended for small churches, chapels, and practice studios rather than medium to large churches like St. Egbert's. It should be noted that the size of the organ does not refer to the volume of the instrument, but rather to the number of manuals, stops, and other features that provide flexibilities and capabilities to the organist.

The stop selection on the current organ is disappointingly lacking in a few areas. First, there is no 8' principal stop in the Swell division. Stops at the 8' pitch are the most important for singing, as this is the most natural octave for the human voice, and principal stops, as the name implies, are the most important stops on the organ. Principal stops produce the characteristic "bright" sound that most people think of when they think of an organ. Principal choruses are used very heavily in liturgical worship as the primary means of supporting congregational hymn singing. The absence of an 8' principal stop in the Swell division results in a hollow sound that lacks adequate foundation. To make matters worse, the 4' principal (Spitzprinzipal 4') is described by Allen as "a hybrid stop which is predominately principal but with a string-like edge," but regrettably it sounds like neither a principal nor a string stop. In fact, it is arguably the worst sounding stop on the organ, which leaves the Swell division with no principal chorus whatsoever.

The organ also lacks reed stops, nasally "edgy" stops that resemble read instruments such as oboes or clarinets. Reeds can be used in any number of ways, but two common ways are to "solo" out a melody line, meaning the melody sounds louder and crisper over the rest of the chords. This makes the melody easier to hear, follow, and sing. This is particularly useful for teaching new songs or bringing a group of singers (choir or congregation) back together if they start fumbling with the melody or tempo in the middle of a song. The only reed stop on this organ is a Trompette 8' stop in the Swell division. While this can be used as a solo stop for processional, recessional, and sometimes offertory hymns, a trumpet stop playing at communion, for example, is much less liturgically appropriate. A second way reed stops are used is to add a subtle crisp nasally edge to a principal or flute chorus, the former of which usually has a bright "ringy" sound and the latter a soft gentler sound. This can help the human ear hear the pitches being played and is often used in the first verse of a hymn to get people comfortable singing the melody. This technique requires a softer reed stop that is not overpowering. The Trompette 8' does not serve this purpose at all.

Having multiple manuals makes it easy to quickly change the sound or volume of the organ in the middle of a piece. This is especially important for liturgical organists in the Catholic church. For

example, responsorial psalms are often played using at least two manuals, one for the soft verse accompanying the cantor only, and another for stronger sound that brings in the congregational response. Additional manuals are handy when there are more musicians to support. For example, playing alongside other instruments (brass, reed, woodwind) requires a different registration than accompanying just a choir or a choir plus congregation in order to not drown out the instruments. The current organ offers no good stop combinations for these purposes. The principal chorus completely overpowers instruments on one hand while the flute chorus inadequately supports singing on the other hand. Given the level of appreciation of music within St. Egbert's parish, the robust congregational singing during Mass, the involvement of numerous instrumentalists, choir members, and cantors, all with different musical abilities, the parish would benefit greatly from a larger instrument with at least three manuals and twice as many stops.

Organ size also means number of audio channels. The current organ has only two channels, with all of the sound being delivered through two large speakers placed side-by-side on the side wall of the church. This is hardly ideal. First, this installation requires the organ to be much louder in volume to fill the church. It is overbearing to choir members and instrumentalists in the music area while sounding fine to congregants across the room. Second, having only two speaker cabinets compromises audio quality by "cramming" more sound through fewer speakers. Consider the difference in experience between a surround sound system and having one or two speakers side-by-side on one side of a room. More speakers does mean more volume: rather, it means a better distribution of sound, making it easier to hear and enjoy with less volume and less distortion.

> For what it's worth…
>
> The installer of the current organ seems to have attempted to compensate for its small size with increased volume, a classic trademark of a poor installation. A larger organ does not mean louder; rather, it means having the right stops distributed across enough properly-positioned speakers to fill the room evenly with clear, crisp, articulate sound.

4. Missing functionality or unconventional behavior

Related to the size of the organ, the organ lacks a number of common features and functionality that assist the organist, enhance the user experience, and make the instrument behave as expected. Some of the more notable deficiencies:

- **No second expression shoe:** The *expression shoe* or *swell shoe* on an organ is one way to change the volume of the organ. On a pipe organ, the pipes of *enclosed divisions* (such as the Swell division) are located behind (*i.e.*, enclosed by) large vertical shutters called swell shutters that open and close to dampen the sound. Three manual organs have two enclosed divisions, each with its own swell shoe, giving the organist much more flexibility. The current organ has one expression shoe that puts the Swell division under expression, which is expected behavior. It also has the option to put the Great division under expression, which would never be true on a pipe organ. The intent of this was to allow the organist to fake having a third division – a Choir division – under expression. The problem with this, however, is that in this mode, *the volume of the entire organ is modified by the single shoe.* This is not the way pipe organs behave and is not really a "feature" but rather an annoying attempt to make up for the absence of an important functionality.

- **No divisional pistons:** *Pistons* are preset buttons that allow the organist to store different registrations, or stop combinations, for easy access. The current organ has seven "general pistons" that control the entire organ. Many organs also have "divisional pistons" that control only one division, which can be very handy for targeted registration changes. This organ has none of these.

  Pistons are sometimes called "thumb pistons" because the buttons are located beneath the keyboard and intended to be pressed quickly by the organist's thumb. Yet, on the current organ, all seven pistons are located below the Swell manual, which is used less than the Great manual, and off-centered to the right, making them difficult to quickly access, especially for left-handed organists.

- **No MIDI:** Modern digital organs come equipped internal MIDI modules containing hundreds of additional sounds to supplement the organ stops. These sounds include additional organ stops and all sorts of instrument sounds, offering an enormous range of musical possibilities, especially for small churches unable to afford to hire instrumentalists. While the current organ is MIDI-ready, this option was never purchased.

- **No lighted music stand:** Most organs come with lighted music stands that eliminate the need for a bulky reading lamp. Unfortunately, the current organ does not have this, which is particularly annoying because the back corner of the church where the organ and musicians are located is notoriously dimly lit.

- **Unnatural transposer switch orientation:** The transposer switch raises or lowers the pitch of the organ to allow the instrument to sound in a different key than what is being played. On this organ, switching the transposer to the left *raises* the pitch, while switching it to the right *lowers* the pitch. This is completely unnatural, as pitch increases from left to right on all keyboard instruments. While merely an inconvenience, it requires the organist to be particularly careful when using the transposer to make sure it is engaged as intended.

5. Console age

The organ console itself is generally in good condition for its age, but it is worth noting that the wooden roll top cover is warped from years of humidity. It does open and close, but not well. Closing the organ, which protects it from dust, abuse, or vandalism, risks the cover binding and becoming stuck closed. The solution to this is to open the top service lid of the console and guide the cover back. The piston buttons have also started sticking and not engaging properly, common issues for these memory capture units when they age.

Proposed Solution

What

The ideal organ for St. Egbert's is an **Allen III/58** to be installed by R.A. Daffer Church Organs, Inc., the Mid-Atlantic regional Allen distributor out of Jessup, MD. The estimated cost breakdown for 2026, which includes delivery, installation, voicing, and a 10-year parts and 3-year labor warranty, is as follows:

Table 1: Cost estimate of an Allen III/58 organ installation quoted September 2026. Prices can be locked in for a period of time with the signing of a contract and initial deposit.

LINE ITEM	**COST**
Allen III/58 organ	$198,200
- Rolling platform	
- Adjustable bench	
- Adjustable lighted music rack	
Buffer for parish expenses (10%)	$19,820
Sales tax	$13,378
Sub Total	**$224,957**
Sales tax reimbursement	-$13,378
TOTAL	**$211,578**



! Important

The cost of the organ includes installation and voicing but not any facilities work that may be needed to receive the organ. Examples might include wall-mounted speaker shelves or speaker wire conduit. A buffer equating to 10% of the project cost is included to cover these expenses, but these costs can often be decreased by utilizing in-house architectural, engineering, and construction expertise and/or donated materials and supplies.

i A note on sales tax

North Carolina state sales tax is paid up front and later reimbursed to the parish. St. Egbert's could consider financing this expense and pay it off in full once reimbursed from the State.

Why

This three manual organ is well sized for St. Egbert church and is loaded with features and flexibilities that can completely transform the parish's music program with stunning tonal quality, remarkable versatility, and exceptional user experience. Some of its most notable features include:

- 66 stops (current organ has 28)
- Six full voice palettes behind each engraved stop: Cavaillé-Coll (French), Arp Schnitger (German), English Cathedral, and Aeolian-Skinner (American), and more
- 264 additional organ, orchestral, and percussion voices and sounds
- Mechanical (moving) drawknobs that give the organ an authentic behavior and an attractive aesthetic appearance
- 32 pistons, including general and divisional pistons, 16 toe pistons, and 128 memory banks (current organ has only 7 general pistons, no toe pistons, and 2 memory banks)
- Two expression shoes and one crescendo shoe (current organ only has one expression shoe)
- Hymn player with 160 prerecorded hymns plus the ability to record and play back anything
- Smartphone sequencing and playback application
- 10 audio channels (current organ has 2)
- Digital Zimbelstern (multi-bell system, *e.g.*, for Gloria at Easter Vigil)

The stop list is extremely versatile, with full principal, flute, and reed choruses in every division. This makes the instrument very capable for accompanying congregational singing with a robust principal chorus from the Great division, cantors with soft yet articulate flutes from the Swell division, choir with supportive but softer principal chorus from the Choir division, and instruments with softer principal choruses from Choir or Swell division. Its six organ palettes offer immense flexibility to adequately accommodate all flavors of organ music and literature from around the world. The large orchestral library supplements the instrument with dozens of string, brass, wind, reed, and percussion instruments that can be played either by themselves or along with the organ.

The current III/58 proposal includes 10 audio channels for St. Egbert's. This includes four low-mid range and four mid-high range speakers plus two subwoofers. The speakers would be installed on a new shelf to be mounted over the main entry doors leading to the vestibule and the two subwoofers would be located in the rear of the church on the floor on either side of the large stained glass window. In addition, an external amplifier rack enclosed in a matching finished wooden cabinet would be co-located with the subwoofers. Locating the amps closer to the speakers, instead of inside the organ console, lessens audio quality loss, shortens wire runs, minimizes the risk of wires breaking or accidentally being cut, and avoids having expensive amps inside the movable organ console, keeping the console weight manageable and somewhat less fragile. Unlike the current installation, which has only two channels, both of which are installed on one side of the church in a corner, this installation will enable 10 speakers to be carefully and deliberately positioned and oriented to optimally direct sound throughout the church, allowing the organ to speak from the tallest part of the room and the sound to distribute evenly throughout the room without needing to overpower the speakers with excessive volume. This setup resembles how a pipe organ would be installed in the church and will constitute a remarkable improvement over the current situation.

This organ also contains a built-in hymn player and recorder module. This allows a non-organist to easily play dozens of pre-recorded hymns with the push of a button or from an app, and the recorder module allows the organist to record additional music, such as Mass parts, to be played back in the same fashion. This would be handy in the absence of an organist and other substitute, especially considering how difficult it has been to recruit substitute musicians at St. Egbert's.

Most importantly, the sound sampling technology provides stunningly accurate pipe organ sound, making modern digital organs indistinguishable from "the real deal." Even non-organists and non-musicians can tell the difference. One has to hear it to believe it, but the congregation can be assured it will not be disappointed! Some examples from YouTube:

- All Creature of our God and King: A beloved traditional hymn familiar to the St. Egbert congregation
- Let All Things Now Living: A familiar thanksgiving hymn often at St. Egebert's
- Ps. 66: Let all the earth cry to God with joy (Alstott): An example of a familiar responsorial psalm accompanied by an authentic-sounding flute chorus
- Obangiji: A festive piece based on a popular Nigerian folk melody by Fela Sowande, one of Nigeria's greatest classical composers and organists
- Trumpet Voluntary: A popular wedding march from the 18th century by J. Stanley (Note that the organ in this video is in a showroom, not an acoustically live church.)

There are many more features and flexibilities that, together with its remarkable sound, make this state-of-the-art instrument a joy to play and not merely a liturgical organ, but a versatile concert instrument as well. The proposal also includes a matching rolling platform for the organ and ample power and audio cable to allow the instrument to be moved to the front of the church to offer, for example, fundraising concerts, if the parish opted to do this in the future. The Allen III/58 is an investment in the future of the parish, as it has the ability to profoundly transform the music ministry and bring music at St. Egbert's to a new level. It is truly worthy of the fourteenth century French composer Guillaume de Machaut's organ moniker, the King of Instruments.

When

While there is not yet an urgent need to replace the current organ, if the parish opts to proactively proceed with replacement before the instrument dies, it is encouraged to do so as soon as fiscally feasible for two reasons: first, prices have been increasing roughly 10-15% each year, and second, the longer the parish waits, the less the current organ could be worth on trade in or private sale.

How

The Allen III/58 is the ideal instrument and its price should be considered the target amount to raise. While financing is available, this is discouraged in favor of taking the necessary time to raise the needed funds to avoid taking on debt.[2] If, after some period of time, fundraising efforts plateau and fall short of the target, other options can be considered based on the amount raised.

Most people and parishes do not give much thought to the monetary value of an organ until it comes time to replace one, so the cost of a new organ can sometimes invoke sticker shock. Parishioners should be reminded that a comparable pipe organ would cost at least 10x more and require regular tuning and maintenance. Put into perspective, a $200k investment over a 35 year period comes out to roughly $100 per week, or about $35 per weekend liturgy, not considering Holy Days, weddings, funerals, and other special occasions. A comparable pipe organ, based on installation alone, would cost $1000 per week or $360 per liturgy, plus maintenance and tuning expenses.

[2]The parish could consider temporarily financing the North Carolina state sales tax, which is more than $12k and must be paid up front but is later refunded back to the parish. The loan would then be paid off in full as soon as the refund is received.

Some fundraising strategies that have proven successful in other parishes include:

1. **Initial ask for money/big donations:** People generally like to donate to projects they can tangibly see or, in this case, hear. Many parishes have been known to end up with a handful of big donations that cover a bulk of the cost.
2. **Fundraising efforts:** Creative fundraising projects, like buying organ keys, pedals, or stops in memory of loved ones, can be effective for the average parishioner. A sample flyer and pledge sheet, made for another parish but easily adaptable to St. Egbert's, are appended as example advertisements.
3. **Capital campaign:** Either a stand-alone long-term fundraising campaign or combined into a larger parish capital campaign. If the latter, it is recommended that parishioners be given the option to give specifically for the organ replacement project.

One advantage to replacing the organ before it no longer functions is that the parish could consider selling it to help offset the price of the new one. Otherwise, the dealer will take it, possibly with a slight "trade in" discount, like when trading in a used car for a new one. There is a market for used organs, either for small churches or home practice organs. For example, a slightly newer Allen digital organ of similar size but with considerably more features than St. Egbert's current organ recently sold for $2,600 on Facebook Marketplace. The internal speaker in St. Egbert's organ makes it entirely self-contained and, thereby, more attractive for a home practice organ. Like any used technological product, like a car, the longer one holds onto it, the less it will be worth in the end.

Analysis of Alternatives

Allen options

The next model down from the Allen III/58 is the III/53. A smaller yet equally capable organ, the III/53 offers 53 stops (compared to 66) and seven channels of audio (six low-mid range speakers and one subwoofer) instead of ten. It also lacks some other "nice to have" features that mostly benefit the organist. Priced at about $186k, which includes mostly the same installation described above, this organ would still be a remarkable improvement and upgrade from the existing organ. The cost breaks down as follows:

Table 2: Cost of an Allen III/53 organ installation quoted September 2026. Prices can be locked in for a period of time with the signing of a contract and initial deposit.

LINE ITEM	**COST**
Allen III/53 organ	$173,425
- Rolling platform	
- Adjustable bench	
- Adjustable lighted music rack	
Buffer for parish expenses (10%)	$17,343
Sales tax	$11,706
Sub Total	**$196,837**
Sales tax reimbursement	-$11,706
TOTAL	**$185,131**

The recommendation is to target the III/58 but fall back on the III/53 if fundraising stalls.

Other brands

The primary competitor to Allen in the United States is Rodgers. The most comparable Rodgers organ models to the Allen III/58 and III/53 are the Infinity 367D and the Imagine 359D, respectively. The 2026 price for the Infinity 367D is estimated to be as follows:

Table 3: Cost estimate of a Rodgers Infinity 367D organ installation based on 16% increase from 2025 prices, which represents the 2024-2025 price increase.

LINE ITEM	**COST**
Rodgers Infinity 367D organ	$220,017
Rolling platform	$4,000
Buffer for parish expenses (10%)	$22,402
Sales tax	$15,121
Sub Total	**$261,540**
Sales tax reimbursement	-$15,121
TOTAL	**$246,419**

Similarly, the quoted 2026 price for the 359D is as follows:

Table 4: Cost estimate of a Rodgers Infinity 359D organ installation based on 16% increase from 2025 prices, which represents the 2024-2025 price increase.

LINE ITEM	**COST**
Rodgers Infinity 359D organ	$157,122
Rolling platform	$4,000
Buffer for parish expenses (10%)	$16,112
Sales tax	$10,876
Sub Total	**$188,110**
Sales tax reimbursement	-$10,876
TOTAL	**$177,234**

While both are remarkable-sounding instruments with many of the same features as their Allen counterparts, they are both more expensive. Besides the cost difference, an Allen organ is being recommended over Rodgers for a few reasons:

1. **Build quality and longevity:** Allen organs are made and built in the United States at their factory in Allentown, PA. The company has earned an industry reputation for solid construction and durability. Proof of this is the number of old Allen organs still in use today – including the one at St. Egbert's. In contrast, Rodgers parts are all made oversees, shipped to the United States, and assembled in Oregon. The most recent lineup of Rodgers models, including the 367 and 359 series, have suffered from notable and unfortunate degradation in quality, including premature parts failures.
2. **Customer service and commitment:** Allen is known for its commitment to every organ it has ever sold, as explained above. The company has built a reputation around standing by its products and providing prompt customer support when needed. Recent company acquisitions

with Rodgers has resulted in deteriorated customer service, leaving some customers with a non-functioning organ for many weeks or months on end waiting for new parts to arrive.

3. **Service availability:** Related to the last point, there currently is no authorized regional Rodgers dealer representing North Carolina, which would make it extremely difficult, if not altogether impossible, to obtain specialized service should a technician be needed.

Another lesser-known manufacture in the United States is Johannus, but these tend to be budget digital organs, which themselves are already budget organs. Johannus organs are ideal for private homes or practice studios, but they do not offer much in the way of mid-size or large organs, so they are rarely found in churches. Their only three-manual instrument is very stripped down compared to either a Rodgers or an Allen and, aesthetically, leaves a lot to be desired. Johannus also lacks the same reputation and track record as both Rodgers and Allen. For these and other reasons, Johannus has not been considered for St. Egbert's.

Pre-owned (used) organ

Pre-owned organs, whether purchased as a private sale or through a commercial organ distributor like R.A. Daffer Church Organs, often cost significantly less than new organs, but there are several reasons why churches should be leery of this idea:

1. **Age:** As discussed above, digital organs generally have a finite usable life span. Assume, for the sake of argument, this lifespan is (generously) 40 years. With very rare exceptions, the newest used organs available at any time are usually 20-25 years old. That currently puts most from the early 2000s, which means they are only about 10 years newer than St. Egbert's current organ. From a human psychology perspective, parishioners think they are getting a new organ, and while it is indeed new to them, a 20-25 year old organ is more than halfway through its reliable lifespan. That means the parish will find itself in the market again in another 15-20 years or so, which is not a long time. Most parishioners will then still remember the previous purchase and think, "We just bought a new organ, why do we need another one?"
2. **Old technology:** Allen and Rodgers tend to update their model offerings roughly every 10-15 years. These major updates are when the largest technological advances get rolled out. From a sound technology standpoint, only Rodgers organs built within the last 10 years should be seriously considered – and for Allen, the window is even smaller: their Apex sampling technology is less than 5 years old, with the latest version coming out just this year (2026). It is within this time frame that the modern sampling capabilities became widely available, and the sound quality is leaps and bounds ahead of organs from even the previous decade. The industry has now reached a point where any new improvements in sound quality capabilities are unlikely to be perceivable by the human ear, just like what has happened in the television industry. Thus, it is advisable to only purchase the current state-of-the-art.
3. **No warranty:** Pre-owned organs are usually sold "as is" without any warranty on the organ itself, though commercial organ distributors will sometimes include limited warranties on installation. Private sales will never have warranties. One can never be confidently certain about the history of a used instrument.

Virtual organ

Virtual organs are an emerging technology, the latest in the digital organ market. Virtual organs use regular computers – a desktop or laptop – and software to generate high-quality sound. There are several software options: Hauptwerk, the most common, started off free but is now subscription based, requiring new versions be purchased as they are released. GrandOrgue is a free open-source alternative, but it lacks comprehensive documentation and there's no guarantee that it will stay free. Organova is a new web-based version, allowing the user to play organ samples directly from the cloud instead of through locally installed software. All of these options offer a wide variety of organ samples from all around the world, and their sounds are as authentic as a modern digital organ.

Virtual organs consist of custom consoles that either contain drawknobs or tabs that control the software, or touch screen monitors that the organist uses to engage or disengage stops. They are designed such that the computer plugs directly into them and the software can be configured to be controlled by all of the stops, tabs, pistons, and shoes on the console.

While these organs cost a fraction of the price of a digital organ, they are rarely found in churches. There are several critical limitations and concerns. First is user experience. A computer-savvy organist may have little trouble adjusting to using a touch screen monitor to control the instrument, but a classically trained organist will undoubtedly find herself out of her element at such an instrument. It may, therefore, be difficult to find someone to play it in the future. Second, they lack the same level of support that one would get from a major manufacturer like Allen or Rodgers. Consoles, speakers, amplifiers, wires, computer, and software must be purchased separately and installed by the church. While not impossible to accomplish with the right expertise in-house, this piecemeal setup introduces many potential points of failure and incompatibility. Third, software running on a computer is inevitably prone to software and hardware issues – crashes, operating system and software updates, computer slowing down over time. A digital organ powers up immediately when turned on, but a virtual organ needs to boot an operating system and load the software. This is not a problem for casual settings like practicing at home, but it raises concerns in a liturgical setting where dependability is paramount. Overall, while promising, this technology is simply not yet mature enough for installation in a church like St. Egbert's.

Pipe organ

Pipe organs are laudable investments: nothing is more authentic than the "real deal," and properly maintained, they will outlive their building. Pipe organs generally cost many times as much as a comparable digital organ, and require regular maintenance, including tuning twice a year. A high quality, well-built rank of organ pipes can cost as much as $20,000 (the Allen III/58 has over 60 ranks, not to mention the fact that it is essentially six different organs in one). Adding costs for case work, console, and electrical and structural engineering, to name a few additional expenses, a new custom pipe organ for St. Egbert's comparable in size and functionality to the Allen III/58 would likely cost 10x as much (*i.e.*, $2M.) Given how authentic modern digital organs are, it is hard to justify such a difference in cost to install a new full pipe organ nowadays.

There are also used pipe organs available, for example, through Organ Clearing House. Some are even free so that the buyer need "only" pay for dismantling, moving, and installation. In some cases, like this historic Aeolian-Skinner organ, are already dismantled and out of its original loft, which is a large cost itself. They are usually in varying degrees of (dis)repair, requiring a partial or complete refurbishing to get them functional again. It is almost guaranteed that the wind chests and pipes

will need to be releathered, one of the most expensive maintenance costs of pipe organs. Additional costs include retrofitting its new home, such as electrical, structural, architectural modifications. The cost of all of this depends primarily on the size of the instrument and its condition, but will almost always be less expensive than the same instrument brand new, since so much of the cost of a pipe organ is in parts and material. A key drawback, however, especially with an already-dismantled organ, is that there is no way of knowing what it sounds like, what works, and what does not.

It has been assumed that a full pipe organ, whether new or used, is out of reachable budget for St. Egbert's. If the parish wishes to go down this route, more research will need to be done and new proposals will need to be sought. It is worth noting that new pipe organs are always custom-built according to desired specifications and room considerations. Because of this, a pipe organ that is plenty adequate for the parish's needs yet is also smaller than the Allen III/58 could easily be designed, so a $2.1M (10x) price estimate could be unnecessarily high.

Summary

The Allen III/58 organ is a remarkably impressive instrument that would be a tremendous upgrade from the current organ at St. Egbert's. With three manuals, 66 stops, hundreds of organ voices across six voice palettes, and ten audio channels, this organ is plenty adequate for the size of the church and the needs of the existing and future music ministry. With the current organ beginning to show signs of its 32 years of service, the parish is encouraged to proactively begin raising funds now so that it can replace the instrument before it dies completely. While the III/58's price tag of $211,578 will require significant fundraising, it will constitute a dedicated investment in the future of the parish: its stunning fidelity to the sounds of pipe organs combined with endless possibilities of stop combinations and orchestral integrations will undoubtedly raise the parish's music program to new levels for decades to come – as one would aptly expect from the King of Instruments.